

Is it the best awesomest thing in the history of the world that will obviously be successful and eventually loved by everyone and adopted by all operating systems and in time we won't even remember what old computers used to look like but we will still all sing to the praise of how glorious our new UIs are, and how brave Microsoft was in delivering us from the Evil UI or yore as all countries of the world come together for the common cause of celebrating the Modern UI?

We have a bet against that future—a hefty sum too. Still the fact is, a lot of what we think about what a GUI should look like is based on what GUIs already look like.

Why does the save icon have a floppy of all things; why is that a convention; who even uses a floppy now? Rather for those faced with a GUI for the first time, that is just the save icon, and the fact that it looks like a floppy is merely a matter of trivia for future school-level quizzes. They learn that it is a save icon and understand what it is when it is used again. If we were to suddenly replace the save icon with a picture of a horse, people would soon learn what it means – while being understandably confused – and a child participating in a quiz in the future would mention this FastTrack as what started this whole trend.

Microsoft believes in this new design language – actually its beginnings can be traced way back to Encarta – and the implications of this UI design will be understood over time.

We said earlier that Microsoft was trending towards non-skeuomorphic designs but why is that even a good thing; shouldn't we be evoking the familiar in order to help people get familiar with computing concepts?

Evoking familiar patterns can be a good thing, but like all good things, they can be overdone. Let's take the example of skeuomorphs outside the field of computers software; take for example the common example of an electric car.

An electric car has no need for a front grill, since the engine does not need air for cooling, even so these cars have such grills. Why? To evoke the familiar design of a car, or for economic reasons having to do with the fact that reusing similar designs is easier in manufacturing. Seems fine enough?

Let's go a step further and add an exhaust, which electric cars have no need for. Now we're just wasting money, but we can go further and install a small smoke machine in it as well, just to get the feeling of a normal car. While we're at it, we all like the roar of an engine, so let's add an engine